pulled up the joy stick. The aircraft, an old war horse, struggled to gain height and we barely missed crashing into the spur at the end of the runway. A few seconds' delay and we would have definitely flown straight into the hill. We were fortunate to have escaped death and were so shaken up we didn't realize that we had slid backwards in the cargo compartment and had a lot of sheep excreta all over us. The pilot tried the same approach a second time and managed to land safely. We were ashen-faced and heaved a sigh of relief. 'Never again,' I said to Deepak, and decided to do the return journey on foot after completing my mission. Today there is a motorable road all the way to Walong and even beyond towards the border.

Another episode that I would like to share happened when we went to our operational locations during October 1982. After the stipulated number of days we sent the report to the Brigade HQ that our defences were not yet ready. As it happened, the other units had given a completion report. The brigade commander wanted to know why we were taking so much time. In those days we did not have computers and the software to make slick powerpoint presentations, yet I requested the brigadier to come to my battalion tactical HQ where I could brief him properly. The seasoned soldier that he was, Brigadier Airy came up to my HQ and I presented to him the facts, logic and rationale of our build-up and preparations. He was convinced. Now the question arose as to how the others were claiming to be ready. When he asked for the details, he found out that some of the units had given an incorrect readiness report. He did not spare the defaulters.

Around the end of January 1983, I received a personal letter from a friend, Lieutenant Colonel Ashok Chaki, who was posted in the Army HQ. It read, 'congratulations on two counts, firstly, for the well merited award of Vishisht Seva Medal and secondly, for being selected for the Higher Command Course, which would be commencing in June 1983.' Although I felt extremely elated, I really did not know how to deal with this bit of news. As official